filed transfer petitions to the SC.

Madhya Pradesh, due to its demographic mix, presently has quotas of 16 per cent for Scheduled Castes and 20 per cent for Scheduled Tribes—both roughly equivalent to their populations. That leaves only 14 per cent for OBCs, who numbered 48 per cent in the 2011 census and exceed 50 per cent in many formal estimates. In 2019, after a central law, it had also implemented the 10 per cent EWS quota. That one expectedly went down everywhere without much demur on the question of merit, and also found the SC more reasonable on the 50 per cent cap. Effectively, MP is at 60 per cent now—a hike for OBCs would take quotas to 73 per cent.

For all that, OBC leaders feel the government is not honest about enhancing the quota for them. "The amendment was done by Congress CM Kamal Nath. The BJP government feels that if the court allows it, the credit would go the Congress, which they wish to avoid," says senior HC advocate Rameshwar Thakur. The OBC Advocates Welfare Association, of which he's president, has filed an application in the SC demanding that OBC quotas be enhanced to 50 per cent in line with the population.

The back story to all this: the past 25 years have seen a resurgence in OBC identity politics in MP. All the four BJP CMs in its 21-year reign—Uma Bharti, Babulal Gaur, Shivraj Chouhan and Mohan Yadav—have been OBC. The Congress, on the other hand, has had two non-OBC CMs, Digvijaya Singh and Kamal Nath. But as PCC presidents, it has had three OBCs: Subhash Yadav, his son Arun Yadav, and incumbent Jitendra Patwari. ■

Takeaways

- **Mohan Yadav regime backs 27% OBC quotas in SC, bid to thwart Cong. claiming credit**
- **16+20% for SCs/STs left only 14% for OBCs, half the state's population. Plus, there's EWS**

▶ GUJARAT

KNOTTED END TO A LONG YARN

Cotton stares at an uncertain future in its heartland as iffy economics, new crops wean farmers away

By **Jumana Shah**



HINDUSTAN TIMES

A THREAD THAT RUNS FROM ANCIENT TRADE to contemporary geo-economics? Yes, India's cotton story is as old as recorded history—going back to Harappan days—and Gujarat was always part of that weave. Even if it's not exactly in danger of fading out like that civilisation, the fabric is running thin. Days before the Centre waived import duty on raw cotton in August, kharif sowing data from Gujarat showed a 15 per cent decline in area under cotton cultivation. It stood at 2.03 million hectares, registering the third straight year-on-year (YoY) dip.

Gujarat is India's second highest cotton producer, after Maharashtra. Together, they account for about 55 per cent of our cotton area and volumes, though Maharashtra also saw a 3 per cent dip in 2024-2025. Gujarat's cotton farmers are shifting to groundnut as part of the National Mission on Edible Oils (NMEO), which targets expanding oilseed cultivation by 4 mha nationally by 2030-31. Gujarat is a priority state here: it already contributes 24 per cent to India's primary oilseed kitty.

With the cotton crisis, the paradox lies in its warp and weft: shrinking acreage along a glut in stock. Overall, India's cotton production has dipped 20 per cent in four fiscals since 2020-21: from 37.1 million bales to about 29.4 million. Yet, the sector is looking at the century's largest carry forward stock of 5.6 million bales at the end of the season, says Atul Ganatra, president, Cotton Association of India. Usually, that weighs in at 3.9-4 million bales on the scales.

MISMATCH TONNES

So, how does low production create excess supply? Put it down to imports and exports. In 2024-25, exports had declined 13 per cent YoY. Significant in itself, that pales on a decadal scale. From 2014-2015, the drop is a staggering 82 per cent. It's into this bleakness that Donald Trump lumbered in. "To give relief to textile exporters